Engraved Plate (Row 2001)

Encyclopaedia Britannica (1771)

Historical source

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SILEX. See FlANT.

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Silefia. bers of black cattle and horſes are brought hither from Poland and Hungary for ſale, thoſe bred in the country not being ſufficient; but of ſheep, goats, game, and veniſon, they have great plenty. As for wild beaſts, here are lynxes, foxes, weaſels, otters, and beavers. The rivers, lakes, and ponds, yield fiſh of ſeveral ſorts, particularly ſturgeons ſeveral ells in length, and ſalmon. Beſides a number of ſmaller ſtreams to water this country, there is the Oder, which traverſes it almoſt from one end to the other; and the Viſtula, which after a pretty long courſe through it enters Poland. The number of the cities and market-towns is ſaid to be about 200, the county of Glatz included, and that of the villages 5000. The inhabitants who are computed to be about 1,821,065 are a mixture of Germans, Poles, and Moravians. The language generally ſpoken is German; but in ſome places the vulgar tongue is a dialect of the Sclavonic. The ſtates conſiſt of the princes and dukes, and thoſe called *ſtate-lords*, with the nobility, who are immediately ſubject to the ſovereign, and the repreſentatives of the chief cities; but ſince the country fell under the dominion of the king of Pruſſia, no diets have been held. The king, however, when he took poſſeſſion of the country, confirmed all the other privileges of the inhabitants. With reſpect to religion, not only Proteſtants, but Papiſts, Jews, and Greeks, enjoy full liberty of conſcience. The greateſt part of Sileſia lies in the dioceſe of Breſlaw, but ſome part of it in the Poliſh dioceſes of Poſen and Cracow. The biſhop of Breſlaw ſtands immediately under the pope with regard to ſpirituals; but all eccleſiaſtical benefices, not excepting the ſee of Breſlaw, is in the king's gift. Beſides Latin ſchools, colleges, and ſeminaries, at Breſlaw is an univerſity, and at Lignitz an academy for martial exerciſes. The principal manufactures here are woollens, linens, and cottons of ſeveral ſorts, with hats, glaſs-ware, gunpowder, and iron manufactures. Of theſe there is a conſiderable exportation. Accounts are generally kept in rix-dollars, ſilver groſchens, and ducats. With reſpect to its revolutions and preſent government, it was long a part of the kingdom of Poland; afterwards it had ſeveral dukes and petty princes for its ſovereigns, who by degrees became ſubject to the kings of Bohemia, until at laſt King Charles IV. incorporated the whole duchy with Bohemia; and thus it continued in the poſſeſſion of the houſe of Auſtria, until the king of Pruſſia in 1742, taking advantage of the troubles that enſued upon the death of the emperor Charles VI. and pretending a kind of claim, wreſted a great part of it, together with the county of Glatz, from his daughter and heireſs Maria Thereſa, the late empreſs dowager; ſo that now only a ſmall part of it is poſſeſſed by the houſe of Auſtria, and connected with the empire, the reſt being governed by the king of Pruſſia, without acknowledging any ſort of dependence on the crown of Bohemia or the empire. For the adminiſtration of juſtice in all civil, criminal, and feudal caſes, and ſuch as relate to the revenue, the king of Pruſſia has eſtabliſhed three ſupreme judicatories, to which an appeal lies from all the inferior ones, and from which, when the ſum exceeds 500 rix-dollars, cauſes may be moved to Berlin. The Lutheran churches and ſchools are under the inſpection of the upper conſiſtories, and thoſe of the Papiſts under that of the biſhop's court at Breſlaw; but from both an appeal lies to the tribunal at Berlin. As to the revenue, the exciſe here is levied only in the walled towns, being on the ſame footing as in the marquiſate of Brandenburg; but in the reſt of the country the contributions are fixed, and the ſame both in peace and war. The ſeveral branches of the revenue are under the management of the war and domain offices of Breſlaw and Glogau. The whole revenue ariſing to the king of Pruſſia from Sileſia and the county of Glatz amounts to about four millions of rix-dollars per annum. Sileſia || Silius.

Sileſia is divided into Upper and Lower, and each of theſe again into principalities and lordſhips; of ſome of which both the property and juriſdiction belong immediately to the ſovereign, but of others to his ſubjects and vaſſals. In regard to the character of the people, the boors are accounted very dull and ſtupid; but of thoſe of a higher rank, many have diſtinguiſhed themſelves by their wit and learning, as well as by their military and political talents.

SILESIAN EARTH, in the *Materia Medica*, a fine aſtringent bole. It is very heavy, of a firm compact texture, and in colour of a browniſh yellow. It breaks eaſily between the fingers, and does not ſtain the hands; is naturally of a ſmooth ſurface, is readily diffuſible in water, and melts freely into a butter-like ſubſtance in the mouth. It leaves no grittineſs between the teeth, and does not ferment with acids. It is found in the perpendicular fiſſures of rocks near the gold mines in Hungary.

SILICERNIUM, among the Romans, was a feaſt of a private nature, provided for the dead ſome time after the funeral. It conſiſted of beans, lettuces, bread, eggs, &c. Theſe were laid upon the tomb, and they fooliſhly believed that the dead would come out for the repaſt. What was left was generally burnt on the ſtone. The word *ſilicernium* is derived from *ſilex* and *cæna*, i. e. "a ſupper upon a ſtone." Eating what had thus been provided for the dead, was eſteemed a mark of the moſt miſerable poverty. A ſimilar entertainment was made by the Greeks at the tombs of the deceaſed; but it was uſual among them to treat the ghoſts with the fragments from the feaſt of the living. See FUNERAL and INFERIÆ.

SILEX. See FLINT.

SILICEOUS EARTHS. See SILICA, CHEMISTRY *Index*.

SILIUS ITALICUS, CAIUS, an ancient Roman poet, and author of an epic poem in 17 books, which contains an hiſtory of the ſecond Punic war, ſo famous for having decided the empire of the world in favour of the Romans. He was born in the reign of Tiberius, and is ſuppoſed to have derived the name of *Italicus* from the place of his birth; but whether he was born at Italica in Spain, or at Corſinium in Italy, which, according to Strabo, had the name of *Italica* given it during the Social war, is a point which cannot be known: though, if his birth had happened at either of theſe places, the grammarians would tell us, that he ſhould have been called *Italicenſis*, and not *Italicus*. When he came to Rome, he applied himſelf to the bar; and, by a cloſe imitation of Cicero, ſucceeded ſo well, that he became a celebrated advocate and moſt accompliſhed orator. His merit and character recommended him to the higheſt offices in the republic, even to the conſulſhip, of which he was poſſeſſed when Nero died. He is ſaid to

Figure 1: *
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